Dynamic Memory Allocation: Advanced Concepts

CSE 238/2038/2138: Systems Programming

Instructor:

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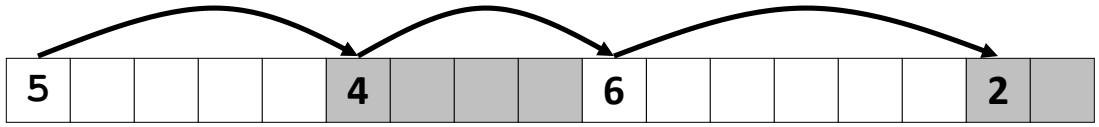
Slides adapted from Bryant & O'Hallaron's slides

Today

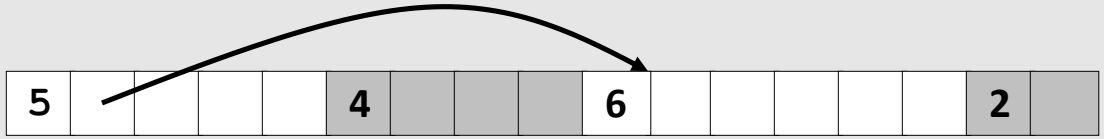
- **Explicit free lists**
- Segregated free lists
- Garbage collection
- Memory-related perils and pitfalls

Keeping Track of Free Blocks

- **Method 1: *Implicit free list* using length—links all blocks**



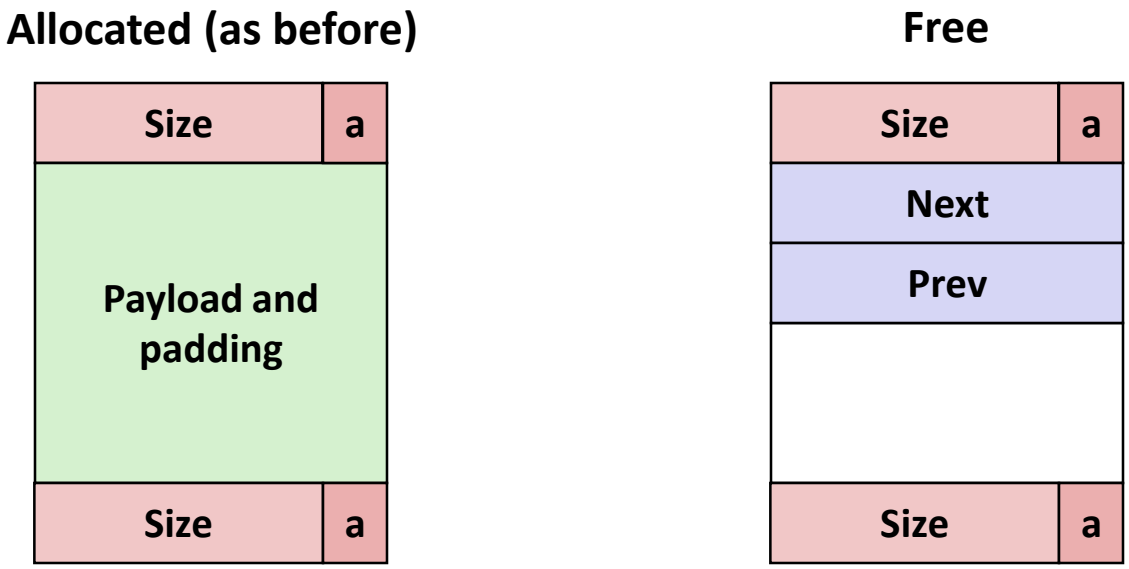
- **Method 2: *Explicit free list* among the free blocks using pointers**



- **Method 3: *Segregated free list***
  - Different free lists for different size classes

- **Method 4: *Blocks sorted by size***
  - Can use a balanced tree (e.g. Red-Black tree) with pointers within each free block, and the length used as a key

Explicit Free Lists



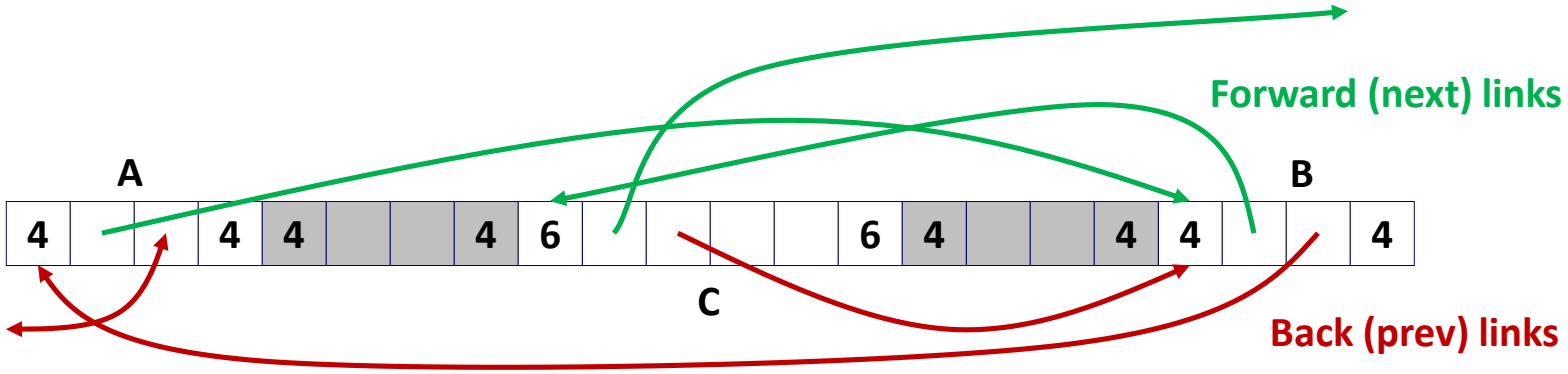
- **Maintain list(s) of *free* blocks, not *all* blocks**
  - The "next" free block could be anywhere
    - So we need to store forward/back pointers, not just sizes
  - Still need boundary tags for coalescing
  - Luckily we track only free blocks, so we can use payload area

Explicit Free Lists

- Logically:



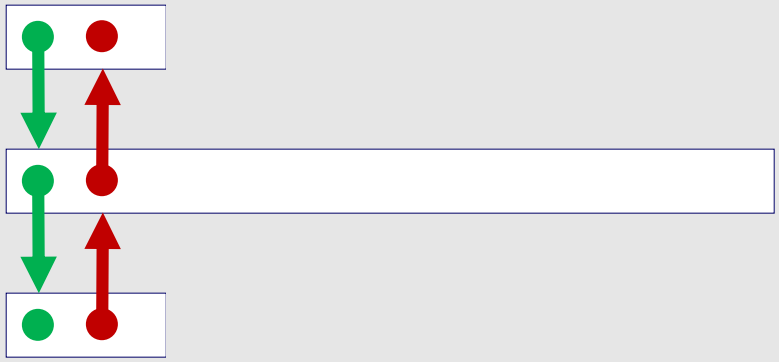
- Physically: blocks can be in any order



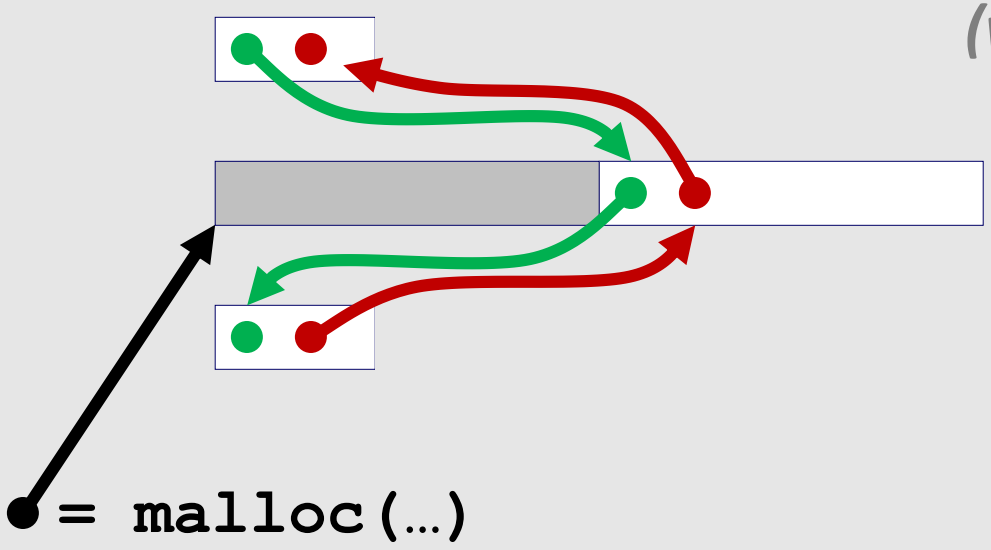
Allocating From Explicit Free Lists

conceptual graphic

Before



After *(with splitting)*

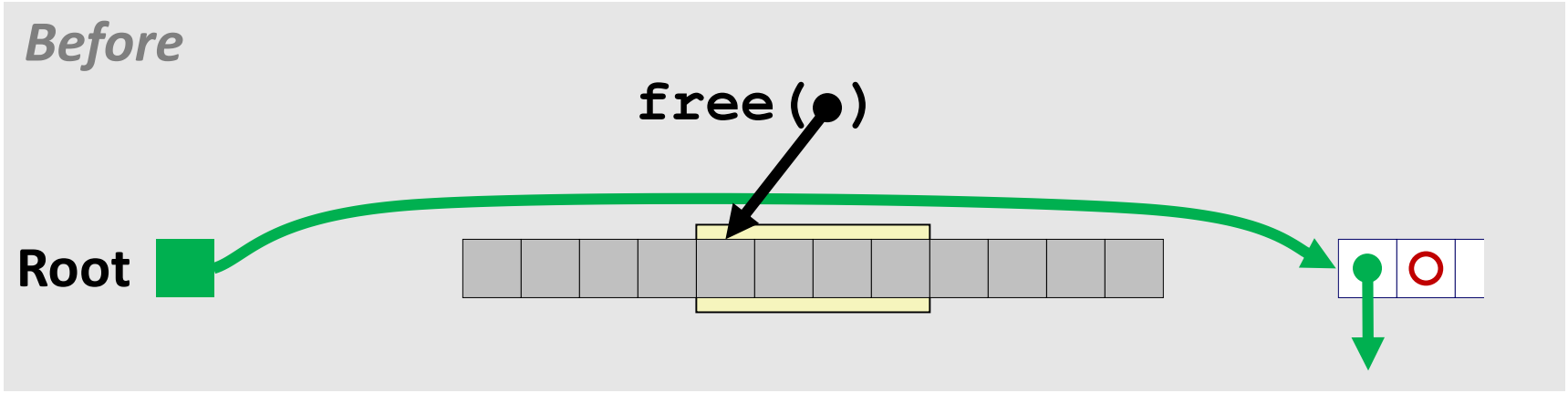


Freeing With Explicit Free Lists

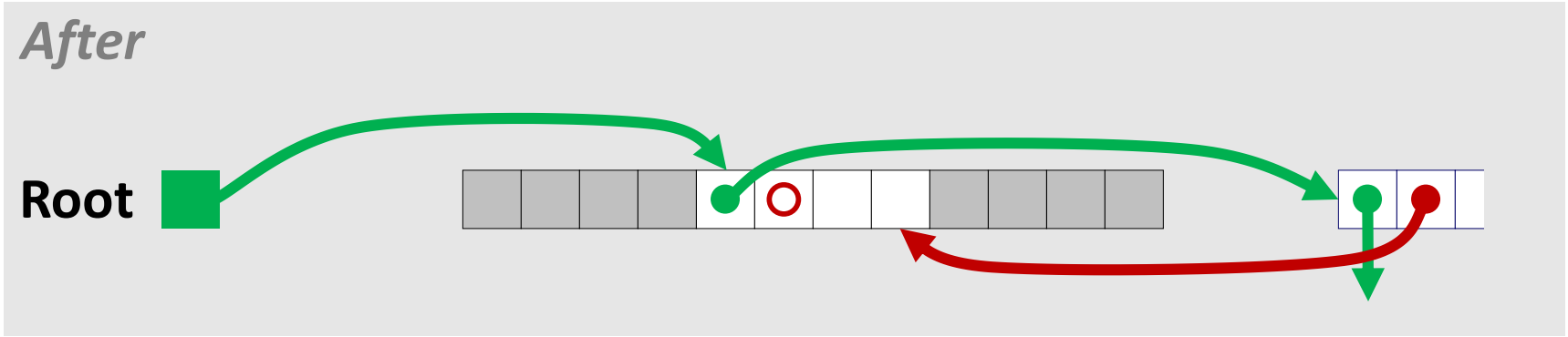
- ***Insertion policy*: Where in the free list do you put a newly freed block?**
- **Unordered**
  - **LIFO (last-in-first-out) policy**
    - Insert freed block at the beginning of the free list
  - ***Pro:*** simple and constant time
  - ***Con:*** studies suggest fragmentation is worse than address ordered
- **Address-ordered policy**
  - Insert freed blocks so that free list blocks are always in address order:
    addr(prev) < addr(curr) < addr(next)
  - ***Con:*** requires search
  - ***Pro:*** studies suggest fragmentation is lower than LIFO

Freeing With a LIFO Policy (Case 1)

conceptual graphic

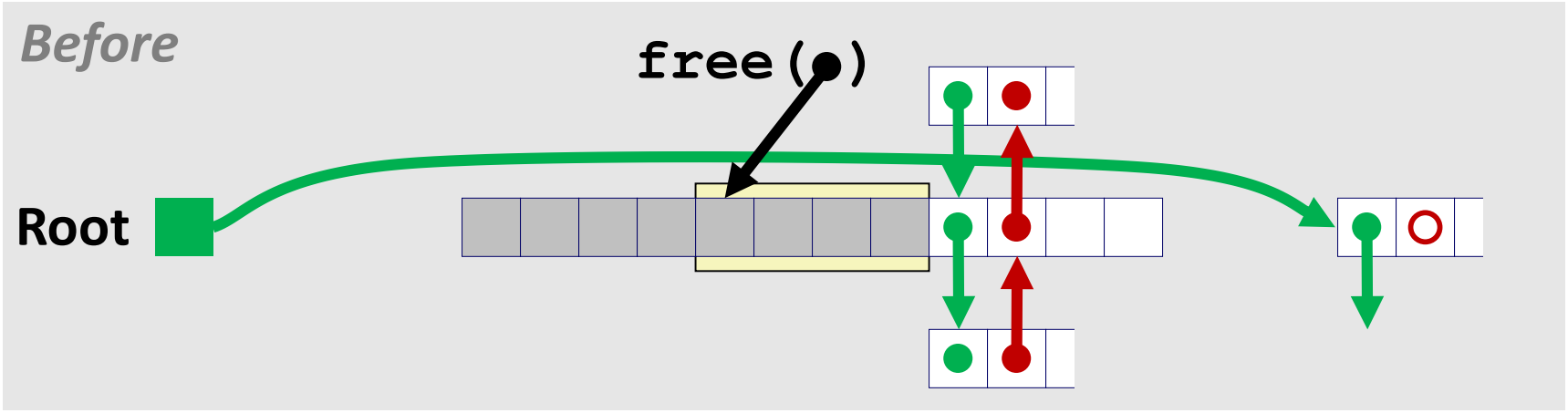


- Insert the freed block at the root of the list

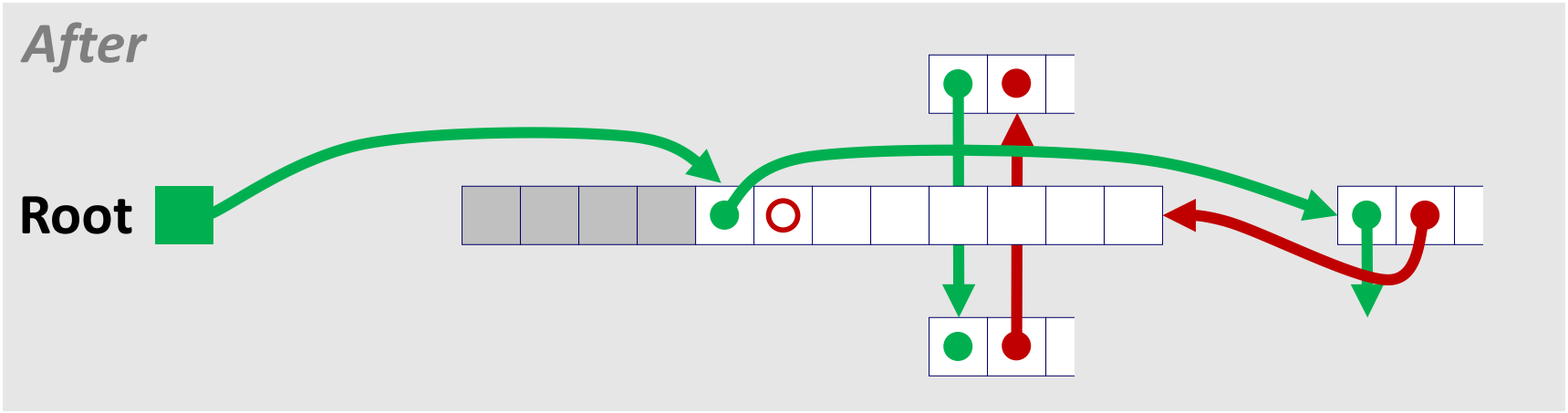


Freeing With a LIFO Policy (Case 2)

conceptual graphic

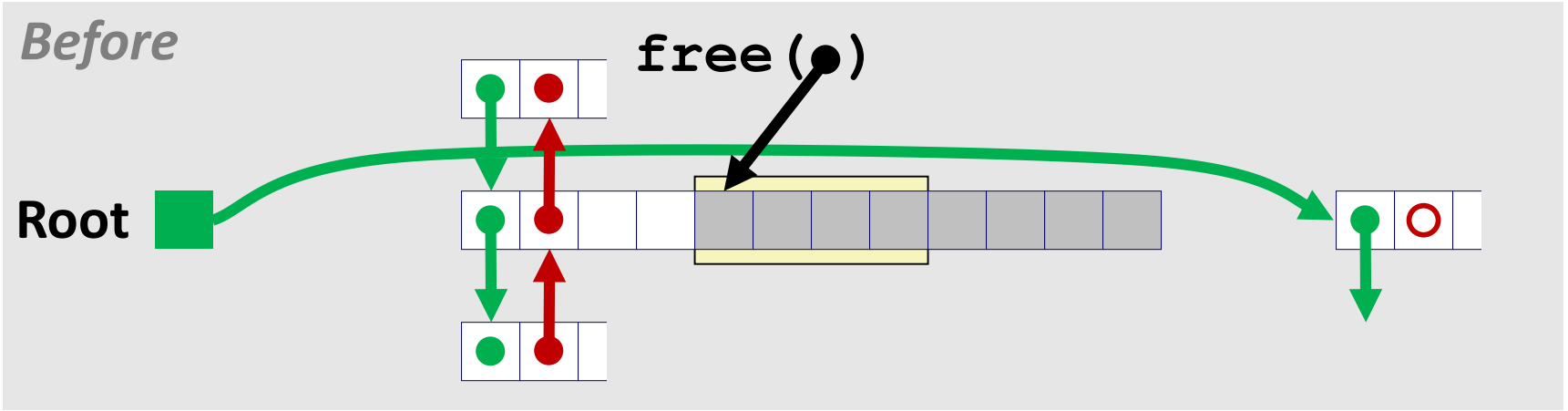


- Splice out successor block, coalesce both memory blocks and insert the new block at the root of the list

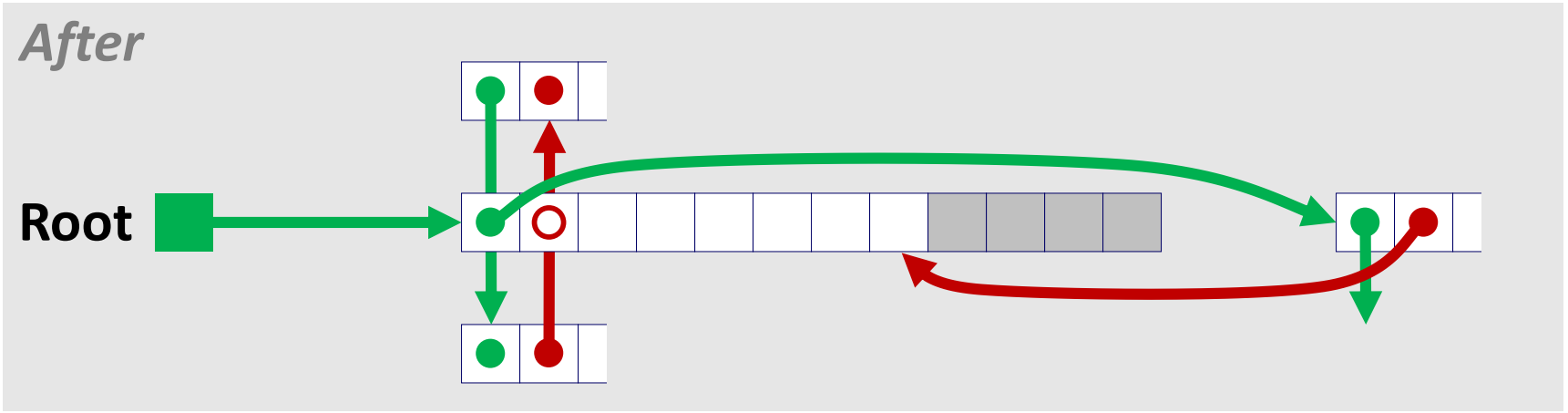


Freeing With a LIFO Policy (Case 3)

conceptual graphic

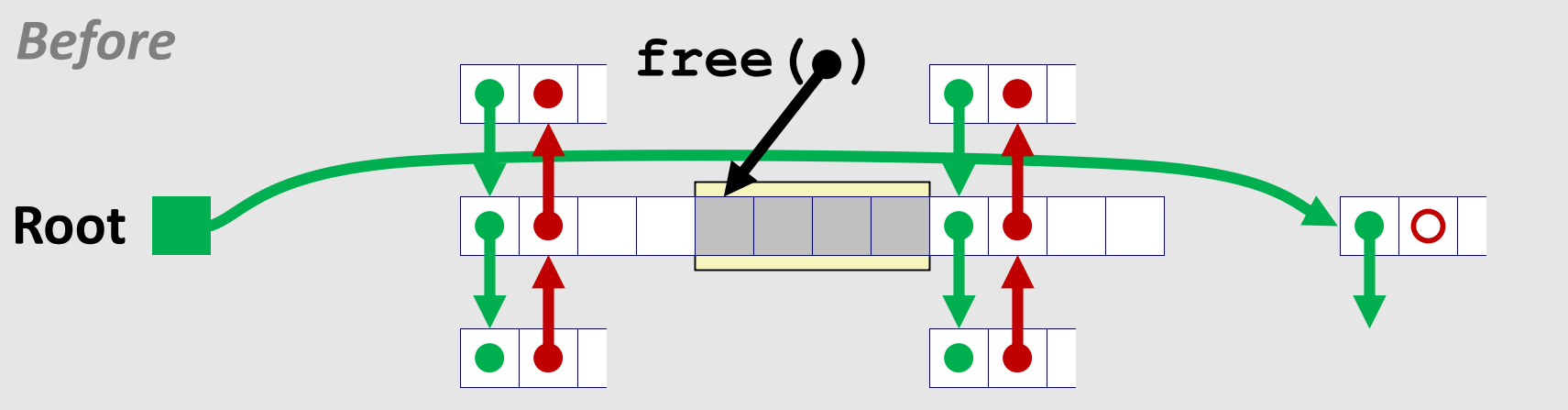


- Splice out predecessor block, coalesce both memory blocks, and insert the new block at the root of the list

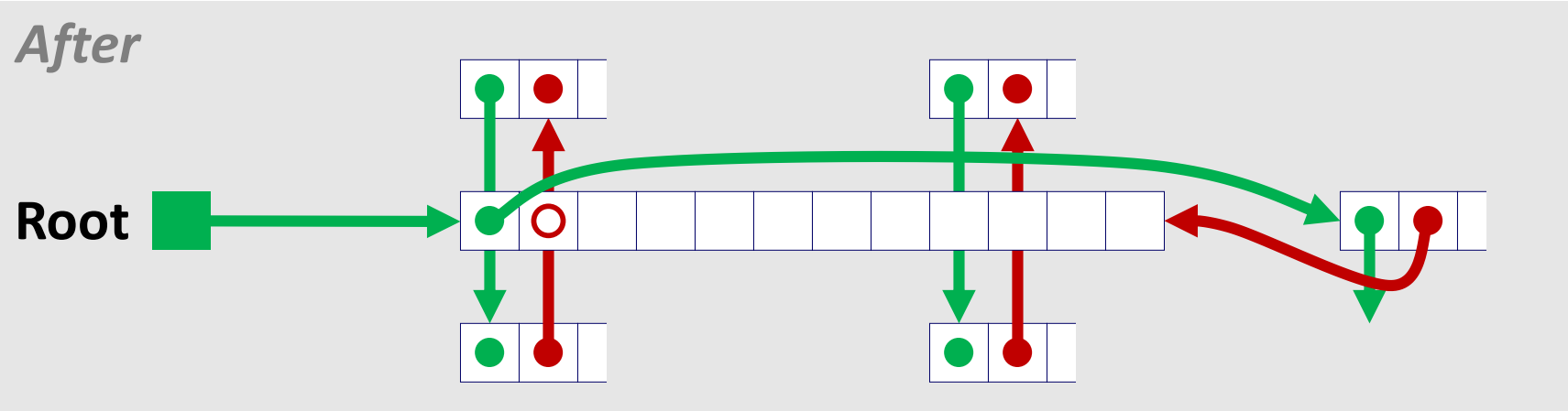


Freeing With a LIFO Policy (Case 4)

conceptual graphic



- Splice out predecessor and successor blocks, coalesce all 3 memory blocks and insert the new block at the root of the list



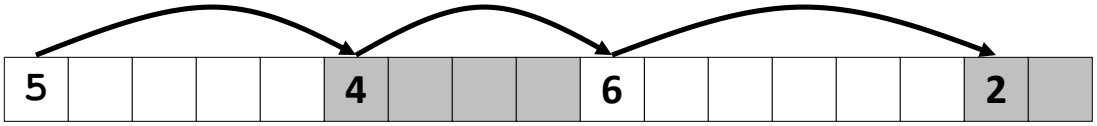
Explicit List Summary

- **Comparison to implicit list:**
  - Allocate is linear time in number of ***free*** blocks instead of ***all*** blocks
    - ***Much faster*** when most of the memory is full
  - Slightly more complicated allocate and free since needs to splice blocks in and out of the list
  - Some extra space for the links (2 extra words needed for each block)
    - Does this increase internal fragmentation?

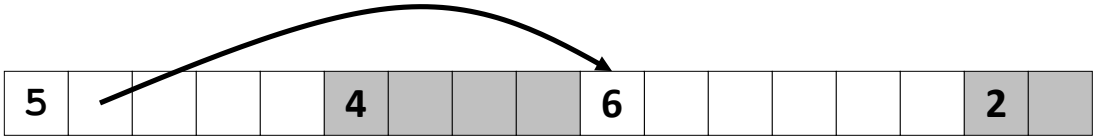
- **Most common use of linked lists is in conjunction with segregated free lists**
  - Keep multiple linked lists of different size classes, or possibly for different types of objects

Keeping Track of Free Blocks

- **Method 1: *Implicit list* using length—links all blocks**



- **Method 2: *Explicit list* among the free blocks using pointers**



- **Method 3: *Segregated free list***
  - Different free lists for different size classes

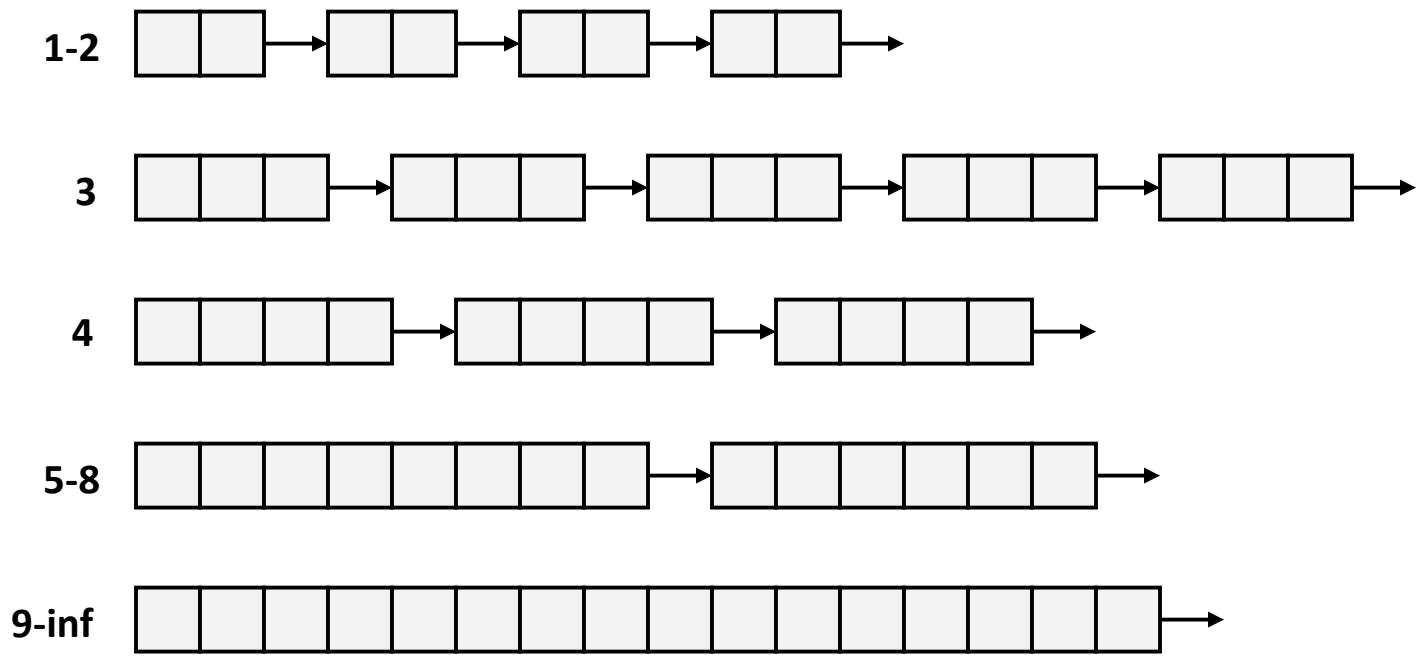
- **Method 4: *Blocks sorted by size***
  - Can use a balanced tree (e.g. Red-Black tree) with pointers within each free block, and the length used as a key

Today

- Explicit free lists
- **Segregated free lists**
- Garbage collection
- Memory-related perils and pitfalls

Segregated List (Seglist) Allocators

- Each *size class* of blocks has its own free list



- Often have separate classes for each small size
- For larger sizes: One class for each two-power size

Seglist Allocator

- **Given an array of free lists, each one for some size class**

- **To allocate a block of size *n*:**
  - Search appropriate free list for block of size *m* > *n*
  - If an appropriate block is found:
    - Split block and place fragment on appropriate list (optional)
  - If no block is found, try next larger class
  - Repeat until block is found

- **If no block is found:**
  - Request additional heap memory from OS (using **`sbrk()`**)
  - Allocate block of *n* bytes from this new memory
  - Place remainder as a single free block in largest size class.

Seglist Allocator (cont.)

- **To free a block:**
  - Coalesce and place on appropriate list

- **Advantages of seglist allocators**
  - Higher throughput
    - log time for power-of-two size classes
  - Better memory utilization
    - First-fit search of segregated free list approximates a best-fit search of entire heap.
    - Extreme case: Giving each block its own size class is equivalent to best-fit.

More Info on Allocators

- **D. Knuth, "*The Art of Computer Programming*", 2nd edition, Addison Wesley, 1973**
  - The classic reference on dynamic storage allocation

- **Wilson et al, "*Dynamic Storage Allocation: A Survey and Critical Review*", Proc. 1995 Int'l Workshop on Memory Management, Kinross, Scotland, Sept, 1995.**
  - Comprehensive survey
  - Available from CS:APP student site (csapp.cs.cmu.edu)

Today

- Explicit free lists
- Segregated free lists
- **Garbage collection**
- Memory-related perils and pitfalls

Implicit Memory Management: Garbage Collection

- ***Garbage collection:*** **automatic reclamation of heap-allocated storage—application never has to free**

```
void foo() {
    int *p = malloc(128);
    return; /* p block is now garbage */
}
```

- **Common in many dynamic languages:**
  - Python, Ruby, Java, Perl, ML, Lisp, Mathematica

- **Variants ("conservative" garbage collectors) exist for C and C++**
  - However, cannot necessarily collect all garbage

Garbage Collection

- **How does the memory manager know when memory can be freed?**
  - In general we cannot know what is going to be used in the future since it depends on conditionals
  - But we can tell that certain blocks cannot be used if there are no pointers to them

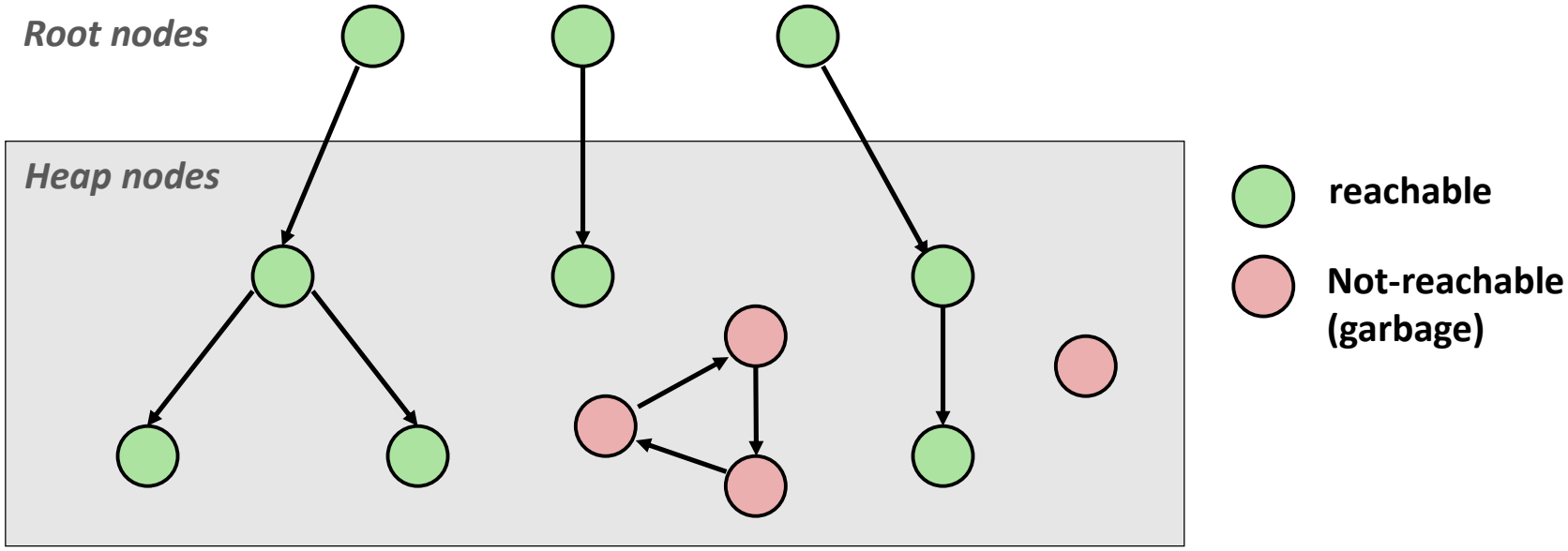
- **Must make certain assumptions about pointers**
  - Memory manager can distinguish pointers from non-pointers
  - All pointers point to the start of a block

Classical GC Algorithms

- **Mark-and-sweep collection (McCarthy, 1960)**
  - Does not move blocks (unless you also “compact”)
- **Reference counting (Collins, 1960)**
  - Does not move blocks (not discussed)
- **Copying collection (Minsky, 1963)**
  - Moves blocks (not discussed)
- **Generational Collectors (Lieberman and Hewitt, 1983)**
  - Collection based on lifetimes
    - Most allocations become garbage very soon
    - So focus reclamation work on zones of memory recently allocated
- **For more information:**
  Jones and Lin, “*Garbage Collection: Algorithms for Automatic Dynamic Memory*”, John Wiley & Sons, 1996.

Memory as a Graph

- **We view memory as a directed graph**
  - Each block is a node in the graph
  - Each pointer is an edge in the graph
  - Locations not in the heap that contain pointers into the heap are called ***root*** nodes (e.g. registers, locations on the stack, global variables)

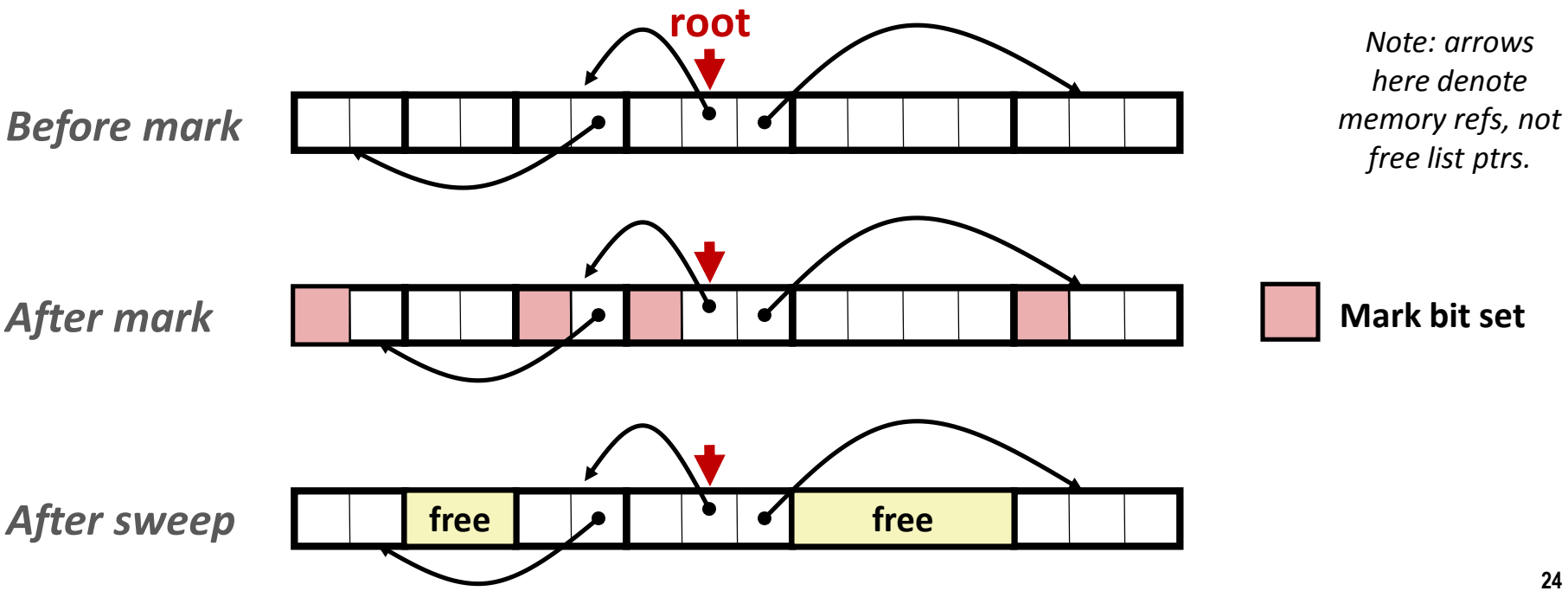


A node (block) is *reachable* if there is a path from any root to that node.

Non-reachable nodes are *garbage* (cannot be needed by the application)

Mark and Sweep Collecting

- **Can build on top of malloc/free package**
  - Allocate using `malloc` until you "run out of space"
- **When out of space:**
  - Use extra ***mark bit*** in the head of each block
  - ***Mark:*** Start at roots and set mark bit on each reachable block
  - ***Sweep:*** Scan all blocks and free blocks that are not marked



Note: arrows here denote memory refs, not free list ptrs.

Assumptions For a Simple Implementation

- **Application**
  - `new(n)`: returns pointer to new block with all locations cleared
  - `read(b,i)`: read location `i` of block `b` into register
  - `write(b,i,v)`: write `v` into location `i` of block `b`
- **Each block will have a header word**
  - addressed as `b[-1]`, for a block `b`
  - Used for different purposes in different collectors
- **Instructions used by the Garbage Collector**
  - `is_ptr(p)`: determines whether `p` is a pointer
  - `length(b)`: returns the length of block `b`, not including the header
  - `get_roots()`: returns all the roots

Mark and Sweep (cont.)

Mark using depth-first traversal of the memory graph

```
ptr mark(ptr p) {
   if (!is_ptr(p)) return;          // if not pointer -> do nothing
   if (markBitSet(p)) return;       // if already marked -> do nothing
   setMarkBit(p);                   // set the mark bit
   for (i=0; i < length(p); i++)    // for each word in p's block
     mark(p[i]);                    //   make recursive call
   return;
}
```

Sweep using lengths to find next block

```
ptr sweep(ptr p, ptr end) {
   while (p < end) {                // for entire heap
      if markBitSet(p)              // did we reach this block?
         clearMarkBit();            // yes -> so just clear mark bit
      else if (allocateBitSet(p))   // never reached: is it allocated?
         free(p);                   // yes -> it is garbage, free it
      p += length(p);               // goto next block
}
```

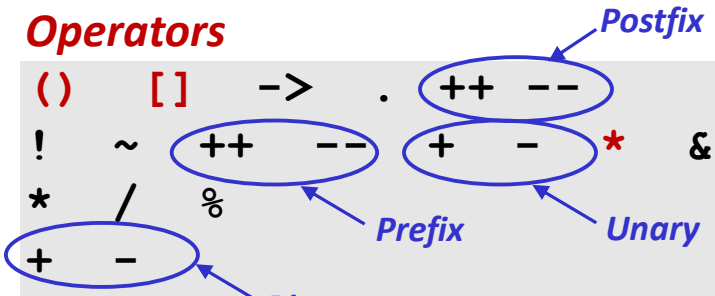
Today

- Explicit free lists
- Segregated free lists
- Garbage collection
- **Memory-related perils and pitfalls**

Memory-Related Perils and Pitfalls

- Dereferencing bad pointers
- Reading uninitialized memory
- Overwriting memory
- Referencing nonexistent variables
- Freeing blocks multiple times
- Referencing freed blocks
- Failing to free blocks

C operators



Operators	*Associativity*
`() [] -> . ++ --`	left to right
`! ~ ++ -- + - * & (type) sizeof`	right to left
`* / %`	left to right
`+ -`	left to right
`<< >>`	left to right
`< <= > >=`	left to right
`== !=`	left to right
`&`	left to right
`^`	left to right
`|`	left to right
`&&`	left to right
`||`	left to right
`?:`	right to left
`= += -= *= /= %= &= ^= != <<= >>=`	right to left
`,`	left to right

- `->`, `()`, and `[]` have high precedence, with `*` and `&` just below
- Unary `+`, `-`, and `*` have higher precedence than binary forms

Source: K&R page 53

C Pointer Declarations: Test Yourself!

`int *p`	p is a pointer to int
`int *p[13]`	p is an array[13] of pointer to int
`int *(p[13])`	p is an array[13] of pointer to int
`int **p`	p is a pointer to a pointer to an int
`int (*p)[13]`	p is a pointer to an array[13] of int
`int *f()`	f is a function returning a pointer to int
`int (*f)()`	f is a pointer to a function returning int
`int (*(*f())[13])()`	f is a function returning ptr to an array[13] of pointers to functions returning int
`int (*(*x[3])())[5]`	x is an array[3] of pointers to functions returning pointers to array[5] of ints

Source: K&R Sec 5.12

Parsing: `int *(*f())[13])()`

`int (*(*f())[13])()`	f
`int (*(*f())[13])()`	f is a function
`int (*(*f())[13])()`	f is a function that returns a ptr
`int (*(*f())[13])()`	f is a function that returns a ptr to an array of 13
`int (*(*f())[13])()`	f is a function that returns a ptr to an array of 13 ptrs
`int (*(*f())[13])()`	f is a function that returns a ptr to an array of 13 ptrs to function returning an int

Dereferencing Bad Pointers

- The classic `scanf` bug

```
int val;

...

scanf("%d", val);
```

Reading Uninitialized Memory

- Assuming that heap data is initialized to zero

```
/* return y = Ax */
int *matvec(int **A, int *x) {
   int *y = malloc(N*sizeof(int));
   int i, j;

   for (i=0; i<N; i++)
      for (j=0; j<N; j++)
         y[i] += A[i][j]*x[j];
   return y;
}
```

- Can avoid by using `calloc`

Overwriting Memory

- Allocating the (possibly) wrong sized object

```
int **p;

p = malloc(N*sizeof(int));

for (i=0; i<N; i++) {
   p[i] = malloc(M*sizeof(int));
}
```

- Can you spot the bug?

Overwriting Memory

- Off-by-one errors

```
char **p;

p = malloc(N*sizeof(int *));

for (i=0; i<=N; i++) {
   p[i] = malloc(M*sizeof(int));
}
```

Overwriting Memory

- Not checking the max string size

```
char s[8];
int i;

gets(s);  /* reads "123456789" from stdin */
```

- Basis for classic buffer overflow attacks

Overwriting Memory

- Misunderstanding pointer arithmetic

```
int *search(int *p, int val) {

   while (p && *p != val)
      p += sizeof(int);

   return p;
}
```

Overwriting Memory

- Referencing a pointer instead of the object it points to

```
int *BinheapDelete(int **binheap, int *size) {
    int *packet;
    packet = binheap[0];
    binheap[0] = binheap[*size - 1];
    *size--;
    Heapify(binheap, *size, 0);
    return(packet);
}
```

Operators	*Associativity*
`()  []  ->  . ++ --`	left to right
`!  ~  ++  --  +  -  *  & (type) sizeof`	right to left
`*  /  %`	left to right
`+  -`	left to right
`<<  >>`	left to right
`<  <=  >  >=`	left to right
`==  !=`	left to right
`&`	left to right
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`|`	left to right
`&&`	left to right
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`?:`	right to left
`= += -= *= /= %= &= ^= != <<= >>=`	right to left
`,`	left to right

Referencing Nonexistent Variables

- Forgetting that local variables disappear when a function returns

```
int *foo () {
   int val;

   return &val;
}
```

Freeing Blocks Multiple Times

- Nasty!

```
x = malloc(N*sizeof(int));
        <manipulate x>
free(x);

y = malloc(M*sizeof(int));
        <manipulate y>
free(x);
```

Referencing Freed Blocks

- Evil!

```
x = malloc(N*sizeof(int));
  <manipulate x>
free(x);
   ...
y = malloc(M*sizeof(int));
for (i=0; i<M; i++)
   y[i] = x[i]++;
```

Failing to Free Blocks (Memory Leaks)

- Slow, long-term killer!

```
foo() {
    int *x = malloc(N*sizeof(int));
    ...
    return;
}
```

Failing to Free Blocks (Memory Leaks)

- Freeing only part of a data structure

```
struct list {
    int val;
    struct list *next;
};

foo() {
    struct list *head = malloc(sizeof(struct list));
    head->val = 0;
    head->next = NULL;
    <create and manipulate the rest of the list>
      ...
    free(head);
    return;
}
```

Dealing With Memory Bugs

- **Debugger: `gdb`**
  - Good for finding bad pointer dereferences
  - Hard to detect the other memory bugs
- **Data structure consistency checker**
  - Runs silently, prints message only on error
  - Use as a probe to zero in on error
- **Binary translator: `valgrind`**
  - Powerful debugging and analysis technique
  - Rewrites text section of executable object file
  - Checks each individual reference at runtime
    - Bad pointers, overwrites, refs outside of allocated block
- **glibc malloc contains checking code**
  - `setenv MALLOC_CHECK_ 3`